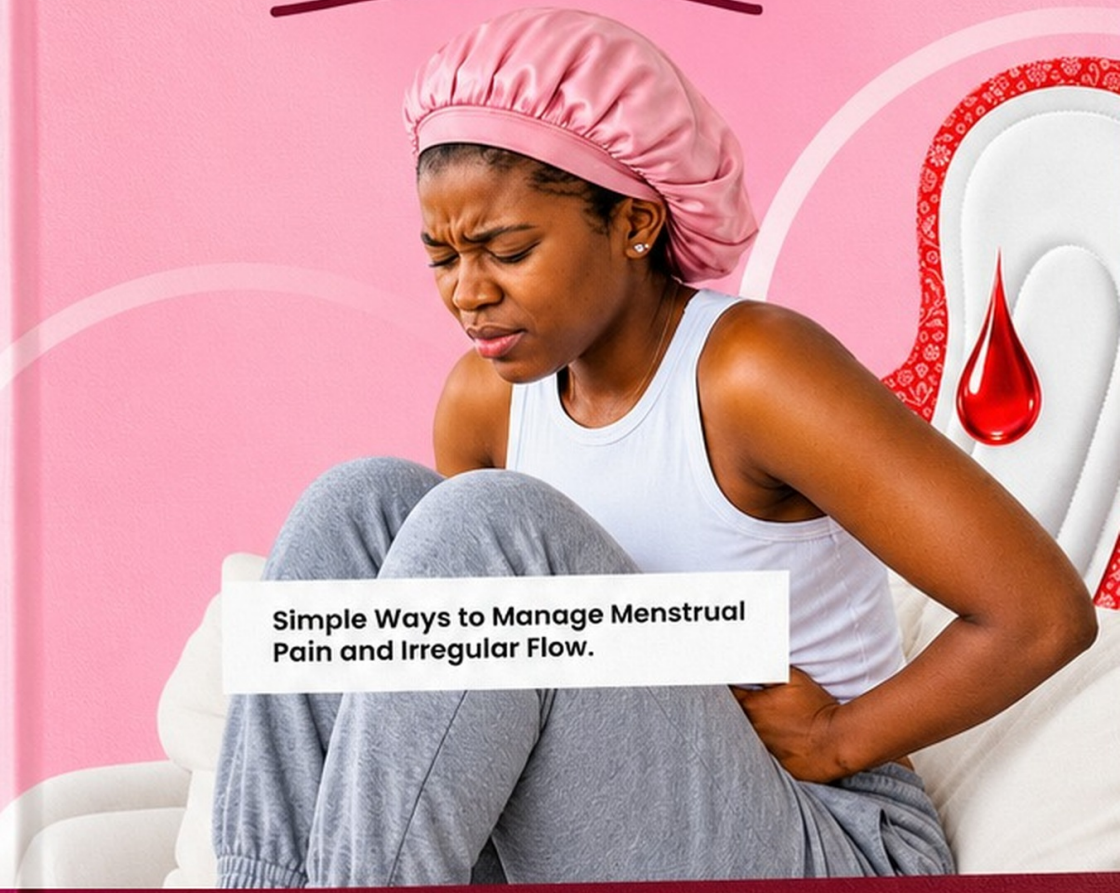
STOP THE PERIOD STRUGGLE



Simple Ways to Manage Menstrual Pain and Irregular Flow.

Women health matters

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Readers with personal health concerns should seek qualified medical advice.

Important: Please Read This First

Please keep these points in mind as you read:

1. **This book supports your care; it does not replace a clinic.** Home care can bring comfort, but it cannot treat every cause of period problems.
2. **"Natural" does not mean "automatically safe."** Herbs and other plant products can cause side effects, can interact with medicines, and may be unsafe in pregnancy or while breastfeeding.
3. **Never use herbs or mixtures to force a period.** If you might be pregnant, this can be dangerous.
4. **Never put herbs, mixtures, or other substances into the vagina.**
5. **Do not stop any prescribed medicine** because of something you read here without speaking to your doctor first.
6. **Some symptoms need urgent care.** These include sudden or severe pain, fainting, and very heavy bleeding. You will find the full list in Chapters 8 and 14. If something feels severe or frightening, do not wait. Get help.

A Warm Welcome

Dear reader,

If you have ever lain curled up on your bed with a hot-water bottle, wondering how you will get through the day, this book was written with you in mind.

Period pain is real. It can make you miss school, arrive late to work, close your shop early, cancel plans, or lie awake at night. You may have heard people say, “It is just a period,” or “All women suffer it.” Perhaps you have even told yourself the same thing.

We want to say something kinder and more accurate: **your pain deserves to be taken seriously.** Some period discomfort is common, and there are safe things you can do at home to feel better. But painful periods are not something every woman must simply endure. Sometimes strong pain is a sign that your body needs proper medical attention.

In this book you will learn:

- how your period and cycle actually work,
- why periods hurt,
- gentle ways to care for yourself at home,
- everyday Nigerian foods that nourish your body,

- what is known, and not known, about popular drinks and herbs,
- what heavy, irregular, and missed periods can mean,
- and when it is time to see a health professional.

We will be honest with you throughout. Where something has good evidence, we will say so. Where something is only tradition, or where research is limited, we will say that too. You deserve information you can trust.

Read at your own pace. Use the checklists and the tracker. And please remember that you do not have to do this alone.

With care,
Women's Health Matters

Contents

Chapter 1	Understanding Your Period
Chapter 2	Why Do Periods Hurt?
Chapter 3	Natural Ways to Manage Menstrual Pain at Home
Chapter 4	Nigerian Foods to Eat During Your Period
Chapter 5	A Simple Seven-Day Nigerian Meal Plan
Chapter 6	Homemade Drinks and Ingredients Women Should Know
Chapter 7	Traditional Nigerian Herbs and Home Remedies
Chapter 8	Heavy Periods and Painful Bleeding
Chapter 9	Irregular Periods
Chapter 10	Missed Periods: What Should You Do?
Chapter 11	Common Period Myths
Chapter 12	Your Three-Month Period Tracker
Chapter 13	Your Seven-Day Period Wellness Plan
Chapter 14	When to Seek Medical Help
Chapter 15	How to Prepare for a Clinic Visit
	Conclusion: Your Body Deserves Care
	References

CHAPTER 1

Understanding Your Period

How your period and cycle work, and what is typical.

Before we talk about pain, it helps to understand what your body is doing each month. Many women were never properly taught this, and that is not your fault. Let us fix that together.

What is menstruation?

Menstruation (your period) is the monthly bleeding from the womb, which leaves the body through the vagina. The blood is made up of the lining of the womb, some blood, and other tissue.

Think of the womb as a small, strong, muscular room. Each month, the body prepares the lining of that room, a bit like making a soft bed, in case a pregnancy happens. If there is no pregnancy, the body does not need the extra lining. It breaks down and leaves the body. That is your period.

Why do periods happen?

Periods happen because of the body's chemical messengers, called **hormones**. Two important ones are **oestrogen** and **progesterone**. They rise and fall during the month. Their changes tell the womb lining when to build up and when to shed.

You do not need to remember the names. What matters is this: a period is a normal part of the reproductive system working, and the whole process is controlled by hormones, which can be affected by many things in your life and health.

Your period is not the same as your cycle

This is one of the most useful things to understand.

- **Your period** is the days when you bleed.
- **Your menstrual cycle** is the whole journey, from the first day of one period to the day before your next period starts.

So your cycle includes the bleeding days and all the days in between.

A simple example of counting your cycle

Imagine Ngozi's period starts on **3 March**. She bleeds for five days, until 7 March. Her next period starts on **31 March**.

- Day 1 of her cycle is the first day of bleeding: **3 March**.
- She counts every day from then until the day before her next period begins, which is 30 March.
- Her cycle was **28 days** long.
- Her period lasted **5 days**.

Always count **from the first day of bleeding**, not from the last day. Light spotting that does not turn into proper flow is usually not counted as Day 1, though you should note it in your tracker.

How long should a cycle be?

Cycles vary from woman to woman. Many adult women have cycles somewhere between about 21 and 35 days, and bleeding that lasts a few days up to about a week. Teenagers who have just started their periods often have less predictable cycles for the first few years.

A cycle can also differ from month to month in the same woman. A cycle that is a few days shorter or longer than usual is often nothing to worry about.

Why does everyone's period look different?

Your hormones, age, weight, health, stress, sleep, and sometimes medicines all play a part. This is why your friend's period might be light and short while yours is heavy and long. Both can be within the range of what is common, but patterns that are new, sudden, or troublesome are worth paying attention to.

Common symptoms around a period

Many women notice some of these before or during their period:

- cramps in the lower belly,
- backache,
- tiredness,
- breast tenderness,
- bloating,
- headache,
- mood changes or feeling more emotional,
- changes in appetite,
- loose stools or constipation.

What is common, and what deserves attention?

Use this as a gentle guide, not a diagnosis.

Often common

- Mild to moderate cramps that ease with simple self-care or over-the-counter pain relief.
- A cycle that varies a little from month to month.
- Some tiredness and mood changes before or during a period.

Deserves attention (see a health professional)

- Pain that stops you from going to school, work, or daily activities.
- Pain that is getting worse over time.
- Very heavy bleeding, or bleeding that lasts much longer than usual.
- Periods that become very irregular or stop.
- Bleeding between periods or after sex.
- Pain that is new or different from what you are used to.

Key takeaway: Your period is a normal body process, but normal does not mean you must suffer. Learning your own pattern is the first step to noticing when something is off.

CHAPTER 2

Why Do Periods Hurt?

The real reasons behind period pain, and when it needs attention.

If your period pain has ever been brushed off, please know this: there are real biological reasons why periods hurt. Understanding them can help you feel less alone and less confused.

What are menstrual cramps?

Menstrual cramps are pains in the lower belly that happen just before or during a period. Doctors call period pain **dysmenorrhoea** (say: dis-men-or-REE-a). It can feel like a dull ache, a sharp cramp, a heavy dragging feeling, or waves of pain that come and go.

Period pain is very common, especially in teenagers and young women. For many women it becomes milder as they get older, though this is not true for everyone.

The role of prostaglandins

The womb is a muscle. During a period, it squeezes (contracts) to help push out the lining. The body makes natural chemicals called **prostaglandins** that help this squeezing happen.

In many women with painful periods, the body makes a lot of these chemicals. More prostaglandins can mean stronger squeezes, and stronger squeezes can mean more pain. They

may also contribute to nausea, loose stools, or headaches that some women feel at the same time.

This is also why some common pain-relief medicines work: they reduce the body's production of prostaglandins. We will talk about this carefully in Chapter 3.

Why can the pain reach my back and thighs?

The nerves that carry pain signals from the womb connect with nerves that serve the lower back and the upper legs. The brain can sometimes "feel" the pain in those areas too. That is why some women feel period pain as backache or a heavy ache in the thighs, not only in the lower belly.

Why do some women have mild cramps and others severe pain?

There is no single answer. Differences may include:

- how much of the pain-causing chemicals the body makes,
- how sensitive a person's nerves are to pain,
- age (younger women often have more painful periods),
- whether periods are heavy or long,
- family patterns (pain sometimes runs in families),

- stress and lack of sleep, which can make pain feel worse,
- and, in some women, an underlying health condition.

None of this means you are exaggerating. Pain is personal, and your experience is valid.

Two types of period pain

Doctors often describe two types.

1. Common (primary) period pain

This pain is not caused by another disease. It usually begins in the teenage years or soon after periods start. It tends to start just before or at the beginning of bleeding and often lasts a day or two, sometimes up to about three days. Many women find it eases with heat, rest, and simple pain relief.

2. Pain linked to another condition (secondary)

This is period pain that is caused by, or linked to, another health problem in the womb or pelvis. It may:

- begin later in life, after years of fairly comfortable periods,
- get worse over time,
- last longer than a few days or start well before bleeding,
- come with heavy bleeding, bleeding between periods, or

pain during sex, bowel movements, or urination,

- not respond well to usual self-care.

Important: You cannot tell which type you have by yourself. Only a health professional can assess this. If your pain fits the second description, please do not just keep enduring it. Book an appointment.

Conditions that can be linked to painful periods

Here are three conditions often mentioned. Please read this section as general information. **We are not saying you have any of them.** Only a clinician can find out.

Endometriosis. Tissue similar to the womb lining grows in places outside the womb. It can cause painful periods, pelvic pain at other times, pain during sex, and sometimes difficulty getting pregnant. It is a well-known cause of painful periods, and it is often missed for years because women are told their pain is “normal.”

Adenomyosis. The womb lining grows into the muscle wall of the womb. It can cause heavy, painful periods and a feeling of pressure in the lower belly.

Fibroids. These are non-cancerous growths in or on the womb. They are common. Many women with fibroids have no symptoms, but some have heavy or long periods, pelvic pressure, or pain.

Other possible causes include infections, ovarian cysts, and problems linked to some contraception devices. This is another reason a proper check-up matters.

Pain that should not wait

Seek urgent care for sudden, severe pelvic pain, pain with fainting, or pain with heavy bleeding, especially if you might be pregnant. See Chapter 14 for the full guide.

> **Key takeaway:** Period pain has real causes. Some pain is common and manageable at home. Pain that is severe, getting worse, or affecting your life deserves medical attention, and you do not need to wait until you “cannot take it anymore.”

CHAPTER 3

Natural Ways to Manage Menstrual Pain at Home

Gentle, low-cost comfort measures, with safety tips and honest limits.

Now for the practical part. These methods are gentle, low-cost, and use things most households already have. For each one, we explain:

1. **What to do**
2. **How to do it safely**
3. **What it may help with**
4. **What it cannot guarantee**

No method works for every woman, and none replaces medical care when pain is severe or unusual. Try one or two at a time and notice what helps you.

1. A warm water bottle or heating pad

What to do: Place a warm (not hot) water bottle or heating pad on your lower belly or lower back.

How to do it safely:

- Never use boiling water. Let freshly boiled water cool for a few minutes before filling the bottle.
- Fill the bottle only partly, push out the extra air, and close the cap tightly.
- Cover it with a soft cloth or towel. **Never place it directly on bare skin.**
- Use it for about 15 to 20 minutes at a time, then take a

break and check your skin.

- If your skin looks very red or feels sore, stop.
- **Never fall asleep with a heating pad or hot-water bottle on you.**
- Do not use heat on skin that has lost sensation, or on broken or irritated skin.
- Check the bottle for cracks before each use. Replace old ones.

What it may help with: Heat can relax tight muscles and bring comfort. It is one of the most widely recommended home measures for period cramps.

What it cannot guarantee: Heat does not treat the cause of pain. It may reduce discomfort without removing it. It will not help severe pain caused by an underlying condition on its own.

No heating pad? A clean bottle or sachet of warm water, or a warm (not hot) towel, can be used with the same precautions.

2. A warm bath or shower

What to do: Take a comfortable warm bath or shower, or sit on a clean stool and pour warm water over your back and belly.

How to do it safely:

- Test the water with your hand or elbow first. It should feel pleasantly warm, not hot.
- Avoid very hot water, which can make you dizzy, especially if you are tired or bleeding heavily.
- Stand up slowly afterwards.
- Make sure the bathroom is safe and not slippery.

What it may help with: Warmth can relax muscles and help you rest. For some women, a quiet warm shower is a welcome break from a stressful day.

What it cannot guarantee: It offers comfort and relaxation, not a cure. If you feel faint or dizzy, stop and sit down.

3. Gentle stretching

What to do: Try a few slow, gentle stretches on a mat or a clean wrapper on the floor. Two to try:

- **Child's pose:** Kneel, sit back toward your heels, and rest your forehead on the floor or a pillow, arms stretched forward or resting by your sides. Breathe slowly for 5 to 10 breaths.
- **Knees-to-chest:** Lie on your back and gently bring both knees toward your chest, hugging them. Hold for a few

slow breaths, then release.

How to do it safely:

- Move slowly. Stretching should feel like a gentle pull, never sharp pain.
- Stop if a movement makes the pain worse.
- Do not force or bounce.

What it may help with: Gentle movement may ease muscle tension in the back and belly and help you feel calmer.

What it cannot guarantee: Stretching may not change the strength of your cramps. It works best as part of a broader care routine.

4. Light walking and comfortable movement

What to do: Take a gentle walk around the compound or house, do light housework at your own pace, or dance slowly to music.

How to do it safely:

- Choose a comfortable pace. You should be able to hold a conversation.
- Drink water before and after.

- Rest if you feel dizzy, weak, or have heavy bleeding.
- Skip intense exercise on days when you feel unwell. Listening to your body is wise, not lazy.

What it may help with: Some women find that gentle activity improves mood and lessens cramps. Studies on exercise and period pain suggest it may help some women, though results vary.

What it cannot guarantee: Movement does not help everyone. On your worst days, rest is perfectly fine.

5. Rest and sleep

What to do: Allow yourself extra rest during your period. If you can, go to bed a little earlier. A cool, dark, quiet room helps. Try a comfortable position, such as lying on your side with a pillow between your knees, or on your back with a pillow under your knees.

How to do it safely:

- Put your phone away 30 minutes before bed if you can.
- Avoid heavy meals late at night.
- Do not sleep with a heating device switched on.

What it may help with: Tiredness can make pain feel stronger. Good rest helps your body cope.

What it cannot guarantee: Sleep does not remove the cause of cramps. If pain keeps you awake most nights of your period, mention this to a health professional.

A realistic note: If you are a student, a trader, or a mother with many responsibilities, full rest may feel impossible. Even small breaks, such as ten minutes lying down, can help.

6. Relaxation and slow breathing

What to do: Try this simple exercise:

1. Sit or lie down comfortably.
2. Place one hand on your belly.
3. Breathe in slowly through your nose for about four counts, feeling your belly rise.
4. Breathe out slowly through your mouth for about six counts.
5. Repeat for three to five minutes.

How to do it safely: There is no risk for most people. If you feel lightheaded, return to normal breathing.

What it may help with: Slow breathing may calm the body's stress response and help you cope with pain. Some women also find prayer, quiet music, or meditation soothing.

What it cannot guarantee: It changes how you cope with pain; it does not remove the physical cause.

7. Gentle abdominal massage

What to do: With a clean hand, use light to moderate pressure to make slow, circular motions on your lower belly, moving clockwise. Do this for a few minutes. A little plain oil or lotion you already tolerate well can make the movement smoother.

How to do it safely:

- Keep the pressure gentle. Never press hard.
- Stop if it hurts.
- Do not massage if you are in severe pain, have a fever, may be pregnant and have pain or bleeding, or have been advised to avoid it.
- Avoid using new oils or strongly scented products if you have sensitive skin.
- Do not use pressure massage to try to start a period.

What it may help with: Light massage may relax tense muscles and feel comforting.

What it cannot guarantee: Evidence for massage in period pain is limited, so treat it as a comfort measure.

8. Staying hydrated

What to do: Sip water regularly through the day. Water-rich foods such as watermelon, oranges, and cucumber also help.

How to do it safely:

- Drink when you feel thirsty and sip steadily. You do not need extreme amounts.
- If you have a medical condition affecting fluid intake (such as kidney or heart problems), follow your doctor's advice.
- Make sure your drinking water is clean and safe.

What it may help with: Good hydration supports your general health and may help with tiredness, headaches, and constipation, which can make you feel worse during your period.

What it cannot guarantee: Drinking water does not stop cramps. It supports your body but does not treat the cause of the pain.

9. A word about pain-relief medicines

Many women use over-the-counter pain relievers for period pain. This is a common and often effective option, and there is no shame in using it.

Safety first: general information, not a prescription

- Some medicines, called **NSAIDs** (non-steroidal anti-inflammatory drugs), such as ibuprofen, work by reducing prostaglandins, the chemicals linked to period cramps. They are widely used for period pain.
- Paracetamol is another common option, though it works differently.
- Taking pain relief **early**, when pain begins, usually works better than waiting until pain is severe.
- Read the label and **follow the product instructions exactly**. Never take more than the stated amount.
- **NSAIDs are not suitable for everyone.** People with stomach ulcers, asthma that is triggered by these medicines, kidney problems, some heart conditions, or those who are pregnant or may be pregnant should ask a doctor or pharmacist first.
- NSAIDs are usually best taken with food.
- Do not combine several products that contain the same ingredient.
- If you are unsure, ask a pharmacist. It costs nothing to ask, and it is a smart thing to do.
- If medicine does not help, or you need it every

month just to cope, see a health professional. Strong pain that needs regular medicine is a reason to find out why.

10. Make a simple period-care plan

The best time to prepare for pain is **before** your period starts. A written plan takes the stress out of difficult days.

Your plan can include:

- **Your tracking:** Note your expected start date (Chapter 12 has a tracker).
- **Supplies:** pads or other products you use, extra underwear, a small bag for school or work.
- **Comfort items:** a hot-water bottle or warm cloth, a light blanket, a water bottle.
- **Food:** a few easy, nourishing meals or snacks you can prepare quickly (see Chapters 4 and 5).
- **Medicine:** any pain relief you normally use, according to its instructions, kept ready at home.
- **Rest:** a plan for lighter duties on your first heavy day if possible, such as asking a family member for help.
- **Support:** tell one trusted person about your difficult days.
- **Warning signs:** remind yourself of the symptoms that

need medical help (see Chapters 8 and 14).

My period-care plan (copy this card into a notebook, or print this page)

Item	My notes
My period is expected around:	
Supplies ready?	☐
Comfort items ready?	☐
Pain relief ready (if I use it)?	☐
Easy meals ready?	☐
Who can help me on a hard day?	
Signs I must not ignore:	

Putting it together

You do not have to do everything in this chapter. A realistic combination for many women might be: a warm compress, a short rest, a glass of water, a gentle stretch, and simple pain relief if appropriate. Notice what works for you and write it in your tracker.

Remember:

- These methods bring comfort. They do not cure the cause of pain.
- If your pain is severe, getting worse, or not helped by these steps, speak to a health professional.
- If you ever feel faint, have sudden severe pain, or very heavy bleeding, seek urgent care.

CHAPTER 4

Nigerian Foods to Eat During Your Period

Everyday foods that nourish you, and what food can and cannot do.

Let us start with something important: **no single food stops period cramps, balances your hormones, or makes a late period come.** If anyone tells you otherwise, be careful.

What food *can* do is nourish your body. During your period you may lose blood, feel tired, and eat less because you feel unwell. Eating regular, balanced meals helps your body cope. The good news is that many of the best foods for this are already in your kitchen and in your local market.

> **Food supports your health. It does not treat every cause of period problems.**

The nutrients that matter, in simple words

Iron helps your blood carry oxygen around your body. When you bleed, you lose some iron. If you lose a lot of blood over time, your iron can run low, and you may feel very tired, weak, or breathless, or look pale. This is called **iron deficiency**, and when it becomes more serious it is called **anaemia** (a-NEE-mia).

Protein helps your body repair itself and gives lasting energy. Beans, eggs, fish, chicken, and groundnuts are good sources.

Fibre helps digestion and can ease constipation, which can make belly discomfort feel worse. Vegetables, beans, whole grains, and many fruits contain fibre.

Fluids keep you hydrated. Water is best, and many foods such as watermelon and oranges add to your fluids.

Vitamin C helps your body take in iron from plant foods. Oranges, pawpaw, guava, tomatoes, and peppers contain it.

Energy (calories): Your body needs enough food to function. Skipping meals during your period can leave you more tired and irritable.

Everyday Nigerian foods and what they offer

Beans and moi moi

Beans give protein, fibre, and some iron. Moi moi, ewa agoyin, and plain boiled beans are all useful. Beans are also very affordable. Adding tomatoes or a squeeze of orange or lemon on the side can help your body use the iron from beans.

Eggs

Eggs are a cheap source of protein and other nutrients. Boil, fry lightly, or scramble them with vegetables. Cook them fully.

Fish

Fresh, dried, or smoked fish provides protein and, in some cases, iron. Whenever possible, choose fish from sources you trust, and cook it well. Smoked and dried fish can be quite salty, so enjoy it in sensible amounts.

Chicken and other proteins

Chicken, turkey, beef, and other meats give protein and iron. Red meat and offal (such as liver) are especially rich in iron, but you do not need them every day. If meat is expensive, beans, eggs, and fish are good choices.

Ugu and other leafy vegetables

Ugu (fluted pumpkin leaves), efo or green amaranth, spinach, and bitter leaf provide iron, fibre, and other nutrients. Do not overcook them until they turn to mush. A short cooking time keeps more of their goodness. Wash them thoroughly.

Okra

Okra gives fibre and is easy to prepare in soup or sauce. It is a good everyday vegetable.

Fruits

Oranges, bananas, pawpaw, watermelon, pineapple, guava, and apples all add fluids, fibre, and vitamins. A banana is easy to eat when you do not feel like cooking. Oranges and pawpaw offer vitamin C. Watermelon is refreshing and mostly water.

Oats and other whole grains

Oats are filling and easy to prepare. Cook them with water or milk and add banana or a few groundnuts. Pap (ogi), brown rice, and whole-grain bread are other options if you can get them.

Rice with vegetables and protein

Rice is a normal, nourishing staple. The key is the **balance**: add vegetables and a protein such as fish, egg, chicken, or beans to your rice.

Sweet potatoes, yam, and plantain

These give lasting energy and some fibre. Boiled or roasted is lighter than deep-fried, though a little fried plantain is fine now and then.

Groundnuts and other nuts

Groundnuts, cashews, and other nuts offer protein and healthy fats. A small handful is a good snack. If you have a nut allergy, avoid them.

Foods and habits to be sensible about

You do not need to give up your favourite foods. But a few simple habits may help you feel better:

- **Do not skip meals.** Regular meals keep your energy steadier.
- **Go easy on very salty, very oily, or very sugary foods** if they leave you bloated or uncomfortable. This is about how *you* feel, not about being "bad."
- **Be careful with tea, coffee, and cola.** Caffeine does not suit everyone and can affect sleep and make some women feel shaky. If you drink tea or coffee, notice how it affects you. Tea and coffee drunk with meals can also reduce how much iron your body absorbs from plant foods. Having them between meals instead can help.
- **Eat what you can tolerate.** If you feel nauseous on the first day, small, simple meals such as pap, plain rice, bananas, or boiled yam are fine.

Heavy bleeding and iron: an important truth

If your periods are heavy or long, you may lose enough iron that **food alone is not enough** to put it right.

Signs of low iron include:

- unusual tiredness,
- looking pale,
- feeling dizzy,
- shortness of breath on light activity,
- a fast heartbeat,
- headaches,
- poor concentration.

If you notice these, please see a health professional. A simple blood test can show whether you are low in iron. Do not self-treat with large amounts of iron products without advice, because iron tablets can cause side effects and are dangerous if swallowed by children. A clinician can also look for the cause of the heavy bleeding, which is just as important as replacing the iron.

What we cannot promise

- We cannot say any food will stop your cramps.
- We cannot say any food will balance hormones or regulate your cycle.
- We cannot say that a food will bring on a late period.

What we can say is that eating regular, balanced meals, drinking enough fluids, and getting enough iron supports your body, especially when you are bleeding.

> **Key takeaway:** Think of food as steady support for your body, not as medicine for period pain.

CHAPTER 5

A Simple Seven-Day Nigerian Meal Plan

A realistic, affordable week of meals, with budget swaps and recipe cards.

This plan uses ordinary ingredients from local markets and shops. It is a **guide, not a rule**. Swap meals around, use what you have, and eat according to your appetite, your budget, and your health needs.

How to use it:

- Eat when you are hungry. Add or remove snacks as you wish.
- If a meal is too expensive or not available, use the "Budget swap" ideas below.
- If you have a health condition (such as diabetes or kidney disease), a food allergy, or specific dietary needs, ask a health professional how to adapt it.
- The plan is meant to be used during your period or at any time.

Day 1

- **Breakfast:** Pap (ogi) with moi moi
- **Lunch:** Rice with vegetable stew and boiled egg
- **Dinner:** Boiled yam with egg sauce (tomatoes, onions, a little oil)
- **Snack (optional):** One banana
- **Hydration:** Water through the day; warm water or ginger tea in the evening

Day 2

- **Breakfast:** Oatmeal with sliced banana and a few groundnuts
- **Lunch:** Beans and plantain with a side of cooked ugu
- **Dinner:** Vegetable soup (efo or ugu) with swallow of your choice and fish
- **Snack (optional):** An orange
- **Hydration:** Water; water with orange or lemon slices

Day 3

- **Breakfast:** Bread with scrambled eggs and tomatoes
- **Lunch:** Jollof rice with chicken and a side of cabbage or green beans
- **Dinner:** Pepper-light fish pepper soup with boiled yam or potatoes
- **Snack (optional):** Pawpaw
- **Hydration:** Water; fish pepper soup counts too as a warm, hydrating meal

Day 4

- **Breakfast:** Akara with pap
- **Lunch:** Rice and beans with a tomato-onion sauce and cooked vegetables
- **Dinner:** Okra soup with swallow and fish or chicken
- **Snack (optional):** Roasted groundnuts (a small handful)
- **Hydration:** Water; peppermint tea if you like it

Day 5

- **Breakfast:** Boiled sweet potato with egg
- **Lunch:** Rice with a simple tomato sauce and fish (a lightly made stew is fine)
- **Dinner:** Moi moi with pap, plus fresh tomatoes and cucumber
- **Snack (optional):** Watermelon
- **Hydration:** Water; coconut water if available

Day 6

- **Breakfast:** Oats or pap with milk and a banana
- **Lunch:** White rice with stir-fried ugu, egg, and a little crayfish
- **Dinner:** Yam porridge with vegetables and fish
- **Snack (optional):** A few cashews or groundnuts
- **Hydration:** Water; ginger tea

Day 7

- **Breakfast:** Whole-grain or regular bread with peanut butter and a banana
- **Lunch:** Beans porridge with plantain and cooked vegetables
- **Dinner:** Rice with chicken or fish stew and a side of sautéed leafy greens
- **Snack (optional):** An apple or orange
- **Hydration:** Water through the day

Budget swaps

- **No fish or chicken?** Use eggs, beans, moi moi, or crayfish for protein.
- **Oats too costly?** Use pap (ogi) or custard and add groundnuts or milk.
- **Out-of-season fruit is expensive?** Choose whichever fruit is cheapest that week: oranges, bananas, pawpaw, or watermelon.
- **Ugu is costly?** Use efo, spinach, or any dark green leafy vegetable at a good price.
- **Meat is expensive?** Add more beans, eggs, and groundnuts. Small amounts of fish or crayfish can add flavour and protein to vegetables.
- **No fridge?** Prepare fresh, small portions. Boiled eggs, beans, and fruit store easily.

Easy recipe cards

Recipe card 1: Simple moi moi

Makes about 6 small servings. Takes about 1.5 hours including steaming.

You need:

- 2 cups of beans, soaked and peeled
- 2 or 3 fresh tomatoes
- 1 small onion
- Fresh pepper to taste (use less or none if pepper upsets your stomach)
- 3 tablespoons of vegetable oil
- Salt and seasoning to taste
- Optional: 2 boiled eggs, flaked fish, or a little crayfish
- Leaves, foil, or small heatproof containers

Method:

1. Soak the beans for about 20 to 30 minutes, then rub them between your hands to remove the skins. Rinse well.
2. Blend the beans with the tomatoes, onion, and pepper, adding just enough water to make a thick, smooth paste.
3. Stir in the oil, salt, and seasoning.
4. Pour the mixture into your leaves or containers. Add pieces of boiled egg or fish if you like.
5. Steam for about 45 to 60 minutes until firm in the middle. A clean knife or skewer should come out clean.
6. Let it cool slightly before eating.

Tip: Moi moi keeps for a short time. Store it in the fridge if you have one, and reheat it thoroughly.

Recipe card 2: Quick ugu and egg stir-fry

Serves 2. Takes about 15 minutes.

You need:

- A large bunch of ugu leaves, washed and sliced
- 1 small onion, sliced
- 2 tomatoes, chopped
- 2 tablespoons of oil
- 2 eggs
- A little crayfish or fish (optional)
- Salt and seasoning

Method:

1. Heat the oil in a pan. Add the onion and fry for 1 to 2 minutes.
2. Add the tomatoes and cook until soft.
3. Add crayfish or fish if using.
4. Add the ugu and stir for about 3 to 4 minutes. Do not overcook it.
5. Make a space in the pan, break in the eggs, and

scramble them, then mix everything together.

6. Season and serve with yam, plantain, rice, or bread.

Recipe card 3: Warm oatmeal bowl

Serves 1. Takes about 10 minutes.

You need:

- ½ cup of oats
- 1 cup of water or milk
- 1 ripe banana, sliced
- A few groundnuts
- A little honey or sugar, if you like

Method:

1. Bring the water or milk to a gentle boil.
2. Stir in the oats and cook for about 5 minutes, stirring often.
3. Pour into a bowl and top with the banana and groundnuts.

A note on honey: Do not give honey to babies under one year old.

A final word on food

If you have a health condition, are pregnant, are breastfeeding, have a food allergy, or have been told to follow a special diet, ask a doctor, nurse, or dietitian before changing how you eat.

CHAPTER 6

Homemade Drinks and Ingredients Women Should Know

What ginger, warm water, lemon, peppermint and other drinks can and cannot do.

Warm drinks can feel very comforting during a period, and that comfort is real. But we want to be clear and honest about what drinks can and cannot do.

In this chapter we separate three things:

1. What has some research support.
2. What is mostly comfort and hydration.
3. What is uncertain or untested.

For each drink we look at: what it is, what the evidence says, what is uncertain, how to prepare an ordinary food-strength version, and what precautions to take.

We will not give strong concentrated mixtures, “boil it for hours” recipes, or dose-based herbal protocols. Food-strength means the kind of amount a person would normally have in cooking or in an ordinary cup of tea.

Ginger tea

Evidence for period pain: some research, promising but limited.

What it is: Ginger is a root widely used in Nigerian kitchens. It contains natural plant compounds, and some of these have anti-inflammatory properties in laboratory studies.

What the evidence says: Of all the drinks in this chapter, ginger has the most research related to period pain. Several small trials and reviews of trials have found that ginger reduced period pain compared with placebo, and some found it similar to common pain medicines. This is promising.

What remains uncertain:

- Most of these studies used measured ginger **powder or capsules**, not homemade tea. We do not know how much a cup of homemade tea provides, so we cannot promise the same effect.
- The studies were generally small, and results varied from study to study.
- Studies mostly involved young women with ordinary period pain, so we cannot say it helps pain caused by conditions such as endometriosis.
- Ginger may help some women and not others.

How to make a food-strength cup:

1. Wash and peel a small piece of fresh ginger, about the size of your thumb tip, and slice it thinly or crush it lightly.
2. Add it to about one cup of water and simmer gently for 5 to 10 minutes.

3. Strain, let it cool slightly, and sip slowly. A little honey or lemon is fine if you like (remember: no honey for babies under one year).

Precautions:

- Keep to ordinary food-sized amounts. More is not better, and large amounts can cause heartburn, stomach upset, or diarrhoea.
- If you take **blood-thinning medicine** or have a bleeding disorder, or if you have **gallstones**, or if you are due for surgery, ask a doctor or pharmacist before using ginger in more than normal food amounts.
- If you are **pregnant or might be pregnant, or are breastfeeding**, ginger in ordinary food amounts is generally part of many diets, but do not use it as a supplement or in concentrated form without advice from a health professional.
- Stop if you get a rash, swelling, or any reaction.
- Ginger tea is **not** a way to start a late period, and is not a replacement for medical care.

Warm water

Evidence for period pain: none, but it is hydrating and comforting.

What it is: Plain water that is comfortably warm.

What the evidence says: There is no good evidence that warm water treats period pain. But it is hydrating, soothing, and many women find it comforting.

What remains uncertain: Whether warm water gives any pain relief beyond comfort.

How to prepare: Heat clean, safe water and let it cool until it is pleasantly warm, not hot. Sip it slowly.

Precautions:

- Make sure the water is clean. If you are unsure, boil and cool it first.
- Never drink very hot liquid; it can burn your mouth and throat.

Lemon water

Evidence for period pain: none, but it makes water more pleasant to drink.

What it is: Plain water with a little lemon juice.

What the evidence says: There is no reliable research showing that lemon water relieves period cramps. It provides some vitamin C and makes water more pleasant to drink,

which may help you drink more.

What remains uncertain: Any claim that lemon water "cleans the womb," "removes toxins," or "balances hormones" is not supported by evidence. We do not make these claims.

How to prepare: Squeeze a small amount of lemon (a few drops to half a lemon) into a glass or bottle of water. Drink it cold or warm.

Precautions:

- Acidic drinks can wear down tooth enamel over time. Sip it through a straw if possible and rinse your mouth with plain water afterwards.
- If lemon gives you heartburn or stomach upset, skip it.

Peppermint tea

Evidence for period pain: limited.

What it is: A tea made from peppermint leaves, available in tea bags in many shops.

What the evidence says: Peppermint has been studied for several conditions, and a few small studies have looked at period pain. The research is limited and not strong enough to say it reliably helps. Many women simply find it soothing.

What remains uncertain: Whether it reduces cramps, and by how much.

How to prepare: Pour hot water over one tea bag (or a small amount of dried peppermint leaves), cover, and steep for about 5 minutes. Remove the tea bag, let it cool a little, and sip.

Precautions:

- Peppermint can worsen **heartburn or acid reflux** in some people. If it does, stop.
- Use ordinary tea-bag amounts only. Do not use concentrated peppermint oil internally unless advised by a health professional.
- If you are pregnant, breastfeeding, or have a medical condition, check with a health professional first.

Other familiar drinks

Plain drinking water. Still the best everyday choice. It costs little and has no side effects.

Fruit-infused water. Slices of orange, cucumber, or pineapple in water make it more attractive to drink. This is mainly a hydration aid.

Coconut water. A refreshing drink with some natural sugars and minerals. A good hydration choice if you enjoy it and it is affordable. It is not a treatment for period pain.

Zobo (hibiscus drink). Zobo is widely enjoyed in Nigeria. It can contribute to your fluid intake, but there is no good evidence that it helps period pain. Some health sources advise caution with hibiscus in pregnancy and for people taking certain blood pressure medicines, because hibiscus may lower blood pressure. Many shop-bought or homemade versions are heavily sweetened. If you like zobo, treat it as an occasional drink, not a remedy, and go easy on the sugar. Women who are pregnant, might be pregnant, or are on medicines for blood pressure should ask a health professional first.

Pap (ogi) as a warm drink. Light, gentle on the stomach, and easy when you do not feel like eating. It provides energy but is not a pain treatment.

Tea, coffee, and cola. These contain caffeine. Some women feel jittery, have trouble sleeping, or find that caffeine makes them feel worse during their period. Notice how you react, and keep these in moderation. Remember that drinking tea or coffee with meals may reduce iron absorption.

A note on other herbal teas and “special mixtures”

You may see products or hear advice online or from friends about herbal “period teas” or mixtures made from several herbs. Please be careful.

- Many of these products have **not been tested for safety or effectiveness**.
- Their strength can vary greatly between batches.
- Herbs can cause allergic reactions, affect how medicines work, and be unsafe in pregnancy.
- **Combining several herbs makes it harder to know what is causing a side effect.**
- Any mixture claimed to “bring down your period,” “clean the womb,” or “open blocked blood” should be avoided. Chapter 7 explains why.

If you want to use any herbal product, speak to a pharmacist or doctor first, and tell them what you are using.

Drinks at a glance

Drink	Evidence for period pain	Main benefit	Key caution
Ginger tea (food-strength)	Some research, promising but limited	Comfort, possible pain relief	Blood thinners, gallstones, pregnancy, upset stomach
Warm water	None for pain	Comfort, hydration	Not too hot; make sure water is clean
Lemon water	None	Makes water more pleasant	Tooth enamel, heartburn
Peppermint tea	Limited	Soothing	Reflux; pregnancy; no concentrated oil
Zobo	None	Hydration, taste	Sugar; pregnancy; blood pressure medicines
Coconut water	None	Hydration	Cost; sugar content

When drinks are not enough

If your pain is severe, if your periods are very heavy, or if you notice any warning sign from Chapters 8 and 14, a drink is not the answer. Please see a health professional.

> **Key takeaway:** Warm, pleasant drinks can be a kind part of your period-care routine. Ginger is the one with the most research behind it, but even ginger is not a guarantee. Keep everything at ordinary food strength, and ask a professional before using anything stronger.

CHAPTER 7

Traditional Nigerian Herbs and Home Remedies

Respect for tradition, honest evidence, and clear safety warnings.

In many Nigerian homes, herbs and traditional remedies are part of how families care for each other. A grandmother's advice, a neighbour's leaf, a market woman's mixture: these are often given out of love, and they are part of our culture. We respect that.

But respect and honesty go together. This chapter explains what is known, what is not known, and where the real risks are, so that you can make safe choices for yourself.

Culture is not the same as proof

A remedy can be used for generations and still not have been tested. "My mother used it" tells us a remedy is *familiar*. It does not tell us that it is *effective* or *safe*.

Think of it in four groups:

1. **Supported by good evidence.** The remedy has been tested well in people, and the results are reasonably reliable.
2. **May give comfort, limited evidence.** It may feel soothing, but research is small or weak.
3. **Traditional, not adequately studied.** It has been used for a long time, but we do not have good human studies.
4. **Possibly unsafe.** There are reasons for concern, such as reports of harm.

Most traditional herbal remedies for period problems fall into groups 2 and 3. A few fall into group 4.

"Natural" does not mean "safe"

Plants contain powerful chemicals. Some of them can:

- cause allergic reactions,
- upset the stomach, liver, or kidneys,
- lower or raise blood pressure or blood sugar,
- change how your regular medicines work,
- affect a pregnancy.

This is why a plant can be a good food and a risky medicine, depending on the part used, the amount, and who is using it.

How we chose what to include

For this chapter, we included a plant only if we could confirm **what it is** (including its scientific name), **what is known about its use and safety**, and **what is not known**. Where we could not confirm these things, we left the herb out. We would rather give you fewer herbs and honest information than a long list of unsupported claims.

Ginger is covered in Chapter 6. Below are two more plants that Nigerian women often hear about.

Herb profile 1: Moringa

Common name: Moringa (also called the “drumstick tree”).
Scientific name: *Moringa oleifera*

How it is traditionally used: In many countries, including Nigeria, the leaves are cooked as a vegetable or dried and powdered. Other parts of the plant, such as the root, bark, and flowers, are used in traditional medicine for various purposes.

What reliable research says:

- The leaves, fruit, and seeds eaten as **food** are generally considered likely safe in food amounts.
- Moringa **leaf** products have been used for up to about three months in studies, without major safety problems reported.
- We did not find good evidence that moringa treats period pain, regulates cycles, or helps heavy bleeding.

What is unknown:

- Whether moringa helps period problems at all.
- How much is “too much” in tea, powders, or capsules.
- Its long-term safety when used as a concentrated product.

Known or potential risks:

- Moringa root and root bark taken by mouth are considered possibly unsafe, because the root contains a potentially toxic substance and the bark contains stimulant chemicals.
- In traditional medicine, moringa root bark and gum from the trunk bark have been used to cause abortion, and when taken that way with black peppercorns, it may cause death.
- Chemicals in the root, bark, and flowers might make the uterus contract.
- Moringa may lower blood sugar, which matters for people taking diabetes medicines. Some sources also say it may affect how the body absorbs a thyroid medicine (levothyroxine) and how the liver processes certain other medicines.
- Allergic reactions, including serious ones, have been reported in rare cases after eating moringa leaves or seedpods.

Why pregnant women, and women who might be pregnant, must be especially careful: Moringa's safety in pregnancy and breastfeeding has not been established, and extracts of the root, leaves, and bark have shown effects that could end a pregnancy in laboratory animals. Moringa leaf cooked in

ordinary food is different from teas, powders, or capsules, and there is not enough reliable information about the concentrated forms in early pregnancy.

Our guidance:

- Moringa leaves cooked in your soup or stew as an ordinary vegetable are a food, not a remedy, and are generally fine for most people.
- **Do not** use moringa root, bark, or flowers as a remedy.
- Do not use moringa as a way to treat period pain or to "bring" a period.
- If you are pregnant, may be pregnant, breastfeeding, or taking medicine for diabetes or thyroid conditions, avoid concentrated moringa products unless a doctor or pharmacist agrees.

Herb profile 2: Zobo (hibiscus)

Common name: Zobo, hibiscus, roselle, sorrel, red sorrel.
Scientific name: *Hibiscus sabdariffa*

How it is traditionally used: The dried red calyces (the flower's outer cup) are boiled to make zobo, a popular drink in Nigeria served at home, at parties, and in shops.

What reliable research says:

- Some studies suggest hibiscus tea may lower blood pressure by a small amount.
- We did not find good evidence that zobo relieves period pain or regulates the cycle.

What is unknown:

- Whether it has any effect on period pain.
- Its safety in pregnancy. Research in pregnant women is very limited.

Known or potential risks:

- Roselle is described in the literature as having emmenagogue effects, which means it may stimulate menstrual flow. One health database lists it as possibly unsafe during pregnancy.
- It may lower blood pressure, so taking it with blood-pressure medicines could drop your pressure too low. The same source says it might affect blood sugar, so people on diabetes medicine should be careful.

Why pregnant women, and women who might be pregnant, must be especially careful: Because of its possible effects on menstrual flow and the limited safety information in

pregnancy, it is wise to avoid regular or large amounts of zobo during pregnancy or if there is any chance you are pregnant.

Our guidance:

- An occasional glass of lightly sweetened zobo is a drink, not a medicine.
- Do not use it as a treatment for period pain, heavy bleeding, or to bring on a late period.
- If you take blood-pressure or diabetes medicines, ask your doctor or pharmacist whether zobo is suitable.
- If you are pregnant or may be pregnant, it is safest to avoid it or ask a health professional.

What about other herbs and “agbo”?

You may know of many other leaves, barks, roots, and mixtures that people recommend for period problems. These include herbal bitters and the mixtures sold as **agbo** or “women’s tonic.”

We have **not** included them as recommendations, for these reasons:

- **We could not verify what they contain.** Many mixtures include several plants, and the exact plants may be

unclear or may change from batch to batch.

- **Strength varies.** Two bottles of the “same” mixture can be very different.
- **Contamination is possible** when products are made and stored without quality controls.
- **Interactions are unknown.** Herbs can change how prescription medicines work.
- **Harm to the liver, kidneys, and pregnancy** has been reported with some herbal products around the world. We cannot tell you which mixtures are safe, so we cannot recommend any unidentified one.

If you still decide to use a herbal product:

- Check that it has a **NAFDAC registration number**, and understand that registration is not proof that it treats period problems.
- Tell your doctor or pharmacist exactly what you are taking.
- Stop it and get medical help if you develop jaundice (yellow eyes), severe vomiting, rash, swelling, unusual bleeding, or any frightening symptom.
- Never give herbal mixtures to children without advice.

Dangerous practices to avoid

- **Never use herbs or mixtures to "force" a period.** A late period may mean pregnancy, and these mixtures can harm both you and a pregnancy. They can also cause serious bleeding.
- **Never use herbs or any mixture to end a pregnancy.** This can be life-threatening. If you are pregnant and unsure what to do, you can speak privately to a doctor, nurse, or counsellor who can discuss your options.
- **Never insert herbs, powders, leaves, or mixtures into the vagina.** This can cause burns, infection, and injury.
- **Never use herbs to treat heavy bleeding without medical advice.** Heavy bleeding can have serious causes, and delay can be dangerous.
- **Do not drink strong or concentrated herbal mixtures, or combine many herbs.**
- **Be cautious of claims** that a remedy "cleans the womb," "removes dirt," "opens blocked blood," "balances hormones," or "cures fibroids." These claims are not supported by reliable evidence.

A kind way to talk to family

If an elder offers you a remedy, you can respect her care without taking something unsafe. You might say:

> *“Thank you, Mama. I appreciate that you want me to feel better. My doctor told me to be careful with herbs, so I will check with the pharmacist first.”*

You can also offer something that is both traditional and safe: a warm meal, a hot-water bottle, or a warm drink such as ginger tea in ordinary food amounts.

> **Key takeaway:** Tradition deserves respect, but safety comes first. When there is not enough evidence, the honest answer is “we do not know yet,” and that is a good reason to be careful.

CHAPTER 8

Heavy Periods and Painful Bleeding

Signs of heavy bleeding, why it matters, and when it is an emergency.

Many women assume that a very heavy period is just “how my body is.” Sometimes it is, but heavy bleeding can also make you very tired and weak, and it can be a sign of something that needs treatment. You deserve to know the difference.

What is a heavy period?

Doctors call it **heavy menstrual bleeding** when the amount of blood affects your comfort, daily life, or health. There is no single number that suits every woman, so it helps to look at how the bleeding affects you.

Signs your bleeding may be unusually heavy

Does this sound like you?

- You soak through a pad or tampon in **an hour or two**, and need to change often.
- You need to **double up** on pads, or use more than one product at a time.
- You need to **get up at night** to change your pad.
- You pass **large clots** (bigger than about the size of a small coin).
- Your period regularly lasts **more than seven days**.
- You **avoid activities** or stay at home because of bleeding, or you worry about leaks and stains.
- You often feel **tired, dizzy, short of breath, or look pale**.

If you tick several of these, speak to a health professional. It is not an overreaction.

Why heavy bleeding makes you tired

Blood carries oxygen, and iron helps make blood. If you lose a lot of blood each month, your body can run low on iron. This can lead to:

- tiredness and weakness,

- dizziness or fainting,
- headaches,
- shortness of breath,
- a fast heartbeat,
- pale skin,
- difficulty concentrating.

This is **iron deficiency**, and in more serious cases, **anaemia**. It is very common in women with heavy periods and it is treatable. Food helps (see Chapter 4), but food alone may not be enough. A blood test can check, and a clinician can advise safe treatment.

Possible causes of heavy and painful bleeding

Only a health professional can find the cause. Some possibilities include:

- **Fibroids:** non-cancerous growths in the womb.
- **Adenomyosis:** when womb lining tissue grows into the muscle of the womb.
- **Hormonal problems,** including conditions that affect ovulation, such as PCOS (see Chapter 9), or thyroid problems.

- **Bleeding disorders:** conditions that make blood clot less easily. These are sometimes missed.
- **Polyps:** small growths in the womb lining or the neck of the womb.
- **Infections** of the womb or pelvis.
- **Some medicines or contraceptive methods,** such as certain coils, or blood thinners.
- **Pregnancy-related problems,** such as miscarriage or ectopic pregnancy. These can look like a heavy or painful period.

A heavy period is not always a “period” at all. If there is any chance you could be pregnant, take it seriously.

Why severe or worsening pain should not be ignored

Pain that is severe, getting worse, or different from your usual pattern is your body’s way of asking for attention. It may be a sign of a condition that needs treatment, and early care often gives better results.

When bleeding is an emergency

Get urgent medical help now if:

- you soak through a pad or tampon **every hour for two or more hours in a row**, especially if you feel dizzy, faint, weak, or short of breath,
- you have heavy bleeding with **chest pain, a racing heartbeat, breathlessness, or severe weakness**,
- you **faint or nearly faint**,
- you have **severe pain** with bleeding,
- you may be **pregnant** and you have pain or bleeding,
- you have bleeding with **fever, chills, or foul-smelling discharge**.

This list is not complete. If something feels severe, sudden, or frightening, even if it does not match an example here, do not wait. Go to the nearest hospital or ask someone to take you.

What to track before you see a clinician

Keeping a record helps you describe what is happening. Over one or two cycles, note:

- the first and last day of your period,
- how many pads you use per day, and how full they are,
- the size and number of clots,
- nighttime changes,
- your pain level (0 to 10) and where it is,
- bleeding between periods or after sex,
- tiredness, dizziness, or breathlessness,
- any medicines, supplements, or herbs you use.

Use the tracker in Chapter 12.

Why home remedies should not delay assessment

Food, rest, and warm drinks can help you feel more comfortable and nourished. They **cannot** find or fix the cause of heavy bleeding. If your bleeding is heavy, long, or tiring you out, please do not spend months trying remedies. A check-up is the safer and faster route to feeling better.

Key takeaway: Heavy periods are common, but “common” does not mean “fine to ignore.” There are checks and treatments available, and the first step is telling a professional.

CHAPTER 9

Irregular Periods

Why cycles change, how to keep a record, and when to get checked.

If your period seems to follow its own timetable, you are not alone. Many women have cycles that do not run like clockwork. This chapter helps you understand what may be going on and what to do.

What does “irregular” mean?

A period may be considered irregular when:

- the time between periods is often **shorter than about 21 days** or **longer than about 35 days**,
- the length of your cycle **changes a lot** from one month to the next,
- you **skip periods**,
- the amount of bleeding keeps changing a great deal,
- periods are unpredictable and hard to plan around.

Important: In the first few years after periods begin, irregular cycles are very common in teenagers and are often part of normal development. Also, a cycle that is only a few days different from usual from time to time is typically not a concern.

Common reasons cycles may change

Periods depend on a delicate balance of hormones, so many things can nudge the cycle. Some include:

- **Stress.** Heavy emotional or physical stress, exams, grief, or big life changes can delay or change periods.
- **Major weight changes.** Losing or gaining a lot of weight, or not eating enough, can affect hormones.
- **Intense exercise.** Very heavy training combined with low energy intake can stop periods in some women.
- **Illness.** A serious or long illness can temporarily disrupt the cycle.
- **Pregnancy or breastfeeding.** Always consider pregnancy if you have had sex and your period is late.
- **Recently starting or stopping contraception** or other hormonal products.
- **Thyroid problems.** The thyroid gland affects many body processes, including periods.
- **PCOS (polycystic ovary syndrome).** A common hormone-related condition that may cause irregular or missed periods, and sometimes acne, extra hair growth, or weight changes. It needs a proper medical diagnosis.
- **Some medicines.**
- **Approaching menopause,** in women in their 40s.

You cannot tell the cause from the symptoms alone. A health professional can help find it, sometimes with a few simple tests.

How to keep a period record

A period record is one of the most useful things you can bring to a clinic.

Each month, write down:

1. The first day of bleeding (Day 1).
2. The last day of bleeding.
3. How heavy it was (light, medium, heavy).
4. Any spotting between periods.
5. Pain and other symptoms.
6. Anything unusual, such as stress, illness, travel, new medicines, or big changes in food or exercise.

You can use the tracker in Chapter 12, a notebook, or a phone calendar or note.

When to get checked

Consider seeing a health professional if:

- your periods are **often irregular** for several months,
- you have **gone three months or more without a period** and you are not pregnant,
- your cycles are **very short or very long** most of the time,
- you have irregular periods **along with** acne, excess hair

growth, or unexplained weight changes,

- you have **bleeding between periods or after sex**,
- you are trying to get pregnant and your cycles are unpredictable,
- you are **worried**, for any reason.

What supports your body (without promises)

Some everyday habits support general health, and may help your body cope with stress:

- **Eating regular, balanced meals.** Your body needs enough energy and nutrients.
- **Sleeping enough.** Aim for regular sleep times where possible.
- **Gentle, regular activity.** Not extreme exercise.
- **Finding ways to manage stress,** such as prayer, music, talking with a friend, or time outdoors.
- **Avoiding crash diets and extreme weight loss.**

These habits are good for you in general, but they **cannot promise** to make your cycle regular, especially if the cause is medical.

What we do not recommend

- No single food, drink, or herb has been shown to reliably regulate a woman's cycle.
- Do not use herbal mixtures sold to "regulate" or "balance" periods. As Chapter 7 explains, their contents and safety are often unknown.
- Do not take hormonal products or tablets that you were not prescribed.

> **Key takeaway:** Irregular periods have many possible causes. Tracking, kind self-care, and a clinic visit when needed are the best path forward.

CHAPTER 10

Missed Periods: What Should You Do?

Common reasons, pregnancy testing, and when to get help.

A late or missed period can bring worry, confusion, or hope, depending on your situation. This chapter walks you through what to think about and what to do, calmly and step by step.

Common reasons a period may be late or absent

- **Pregnancy.**
- **Stress** or a big life change.
- **Weight changes** or not eating enough.
- **Intense exercise.**
- **Illness.**
- **Breastfeeding.**
- **Hormonal conditions,** such as PCOS or thyroid problems.
- **Starting or stopping contraception.**
- **Some medicines.**
- **Perimenopause** (the years before menopause).

Sometimes the cause is never clear, and the period simply returns on its own. But you should not assume this when something else may be going on.

Why pregnancy should be considered

If you have had sex, **pregnancy is one of the first things to rule out**, even if you used contraception, because no method is perfect. Also, it is possible to have light bleeding or spotting early in pregnancy that looks like a period.

A missed period does **not** always mean pregnancy (see the myths in Chapter 11), but checking is the safe first step.

How to take a home pregnancy test

1. **Buy a test from a trusted pharmacy** and check the expiry date.
2. **Read the instructions that come in the box.** Different brands work slightly differently, including when to test and how long to wait for the result.
3. Many tests give more reliable results from the day your period is due, or later. Testing too early can give a false negative.
4. Using your **first urine of the morning** is often suggested because it is more concentrated, but follow your test's instructions.
5. Wait the full time stated before reading the result. Do not read it long after the stated time.

If the test is negative

- If you tested **early**, repeat it after a few days, and again if your period still has not come.
- If your period is still missing after a negative test, **speak to a health professional.**

If the test is positive

- See a doctor, nurse, or midwife to confirm and to plan antenatal care. If you have pain or bleeding, go promptly.
- If this is unexpected and you feel overwhelmed, you are allowed to take time and talk to someone you trust. A health professional can discuss your situation privately and without judgement.

When to speak to a healthcare professional

Please arrange a visit if:

- you have missed **one period and your pregnancy test is positive**,
- you have missed **several periods in a row**, and your tests are negative,
- you have had **no period for three months or more**,
- you have missed periods with **unexplained weight change, hair growth, acne, breast milk when not pregnant, or hot flushes**,
- you are **worried or distressed**.

Never use herbs or mixtures to force a period

It can be tempting to take a drink or herbal mixture to "bring down" a late period. **Please do not.**

- If you are pregnant, these mixtures can harm you and the pregnancy.
- Some can cause dangerous bleeding, poisoning, or organ damage.
- They do not solve the reason your period is late.
- If the cause is a medical condition, delay can allow it to worsen.

A negative test and a conversation with a health professional is a safer path than any mixture.

When a missed period is an emergency

Get urgent medical help now if you have a missed period and:

- **severe pain** in your lower belly or pelvis, especially on one side,
- **fainting, severe dizziness, or shoulder-tip pain,**
- **heavy bleeding,**
- or you **might be pregnant** and have pain or bleeding.

These can be signs of a serious problem such as an **ectopic pregnancy**, where a pregnancy grows outside the womb. This is a medical emergency. Go to the nearest hospital without delay.

This list is not exhaustive. Trust your instincts: if you feel very unwell, get help.

A step-by-step guide for a late period

1. **Check the date.** Count from Day 1 of your last period using your tracker.
2. **Think about pregnancy.** If it is possible, take a test at

the right time.

3. **Repeat the test** if it is negative and your period still has not come.
4. **Look after yourself:** eat regularly, rest, and manage stress.
5. **If no period after a few weeks or several months, or if you are worried, see a health professional.**
6. **If you have severe pain, fainting, or heavy bleeding, seek urgent care.**

> **Key takeaway:** A missed period is a message from your body, not a failure. Testing, tracking, and talking to a professional are safe and sensible steps. Herbal mixtures are not.

CHAPTER 11

Common Period Myths

Clear, kind answers to the myths women hear most.

Myths about periods are everywhere: at home, in school, in markets, and online. Many are passed on with good intentions, but some can keep women suffering in silence or put their health at risk. Let us look at the facts, gently and clearly.

MYTH 1: “Every painful period is normal.”

FACT: Some period discomfort is common, but pain that is severe, getting worse, or stopping you from school, work, or daily life is not something you must accept. It can sometimes point to a condition such as endometriosis, adenomyosis, or fibroids. A health professional can help find out.

MYTH 2: “Severe pain must simply be endured.”

FACT: You do not have to suffer in silence. There are safe options at home and effective treatments from health professionals. Needing help is not weakness, and you do not have to wait until the pain is unbearable.

MYTH 3: “A missed period always means pregnancy.”

FACT: Pregnancy is one possible reason, and it should be checked if it could apply to you. But stress, weight changes, illness, intense exercise, hormonal conditions, thyroid problems, breastfeeding, and some medicines can all delay or stop periods.

MYTH 4: “Herbal remedies are automatically safe because they are natural.”

FACT: Plants contain strong chemicals. Some herbs can harm the liver or kidneys, interact with medicines, cause allergic reactions, or be unsafe in pregnancy. Unlabelled mixtures are especially risky because we do not know what is in them or how strong they are.

MYTH 5: “Certain foods can permanently stop menstrual cramps.”

FACT: No food has been shown to permanently stop cramps. Balanced meals support your general health and energy, and some women find ginger helpful for comfort, but no food is a cure. Be cautious about anyone who promises one.

MYTH 6: “Every irregular cycle can be fixed at home.”

FACT: Rest, regular meals, and stress management support your general wellbeing, but irregular periods can have medical causes such as thyroid problems or PCOS. If your cycles stay irregular, a check-up is the way to find out why.

MYTH 7: “Heavy bleeding is always normal for some women.”

FACT: Some women have heavier periods than others, but bleeding that soaks through pads quickly, lasts more than a week, includes large clots, or leaves you exhausted is worth checking. Heavy bleeding can lead to iron deficiency and can have treatable causes.

MYTH 8: “Menstrual blood is dirty or poisonous.”

FACT: Menstrual blood is not dirty or toxic. It is made up of blood and tissue from the womb lining, and it is a normal part of a healthy body. A woman on her period is not unclean, and she does not need to be excluded from cooking, praying, or normal life because of it. Good hygiene simply means changing pads or other products regularly and washing your hands.

BONUS MYTH: “Exercise and bathing are bad during your period.”

FACT: Gentle movement and warm showers are generally fine and often comforting. Listen to your body: rest on hard days, and move when you feel able.

BONUS MYTH: “You should not talk about periods.”

FACT: Talking about periods helps women get the right care sooner. Silence and shame keep problems hidden.

Key takeaway: When you hear advice about your body, ask: “Is this true, and is it safe for me?” If you are unsure, ask a pharmacist or health professional.

CHAPTER 12

Your Three-Month Period Tracker

A printable tracker to spot patterns and talk clearly to a clinician.

Tracking your period is one of the simplest and most powerful things you can do. It costs almost nothing, takes a few minutes, and helps you:

- **learn your pattern,** so you know what is usual for you,
- **notice changes early,** such as a longer cycle or heavier bleeding,
- **see what helps,** by noting which remedies seemed to ease your pain,
- **speak clearly to a clinician.** "My pain was 8 out of 10 on days 1 and 2, three months in a row" is much more useful than "I have bad periods."

How to use this tracker

1. **Print this chapter,** or copy the tables into a notebook, or use the notes app on your phone.
2. **Day 1 is the first day of real bleeding,** not light spotting.
3. **Each day you bleed,** fill in one row of the daily log below.
4. **Flow:** write L (light), M (medium), or H (heavy). For heavy, you can also note how many pads you used.
5. **Pain level:** 0 means no pain, 5 means moderate pain that is hard to ignore, and 10 means the worst pain you can imagine.

6. **Pain location:** lower belly, back, thighs, or other.
7. **Remedies and medicines:** note everything, including heat, rest, food, drinks, pain relievers, and herbs.
8. **Helped?** Write Yes, A little, or No.
9. **At the end of each cycle,** fill in the cycle summary.
10. **Bring the tracker to your clinic visit,** if you go.

Cycle summary (3 months)

What to record	Month 1	Month 2	Month 3
First day of bleeding (Day 1)			
Last day of bleeding			
Number of bleeding days			
Cycle length (Day 1 to the day before the next Day 1)			
Overall flow (light / medium / heavy)			
Highest pain score (0 to 10)			
Days pain was bad			
Missed school, work, or activities?			
Spotting or bleeding between periods?			
Most helpful remedy			

Daily log: Month 1

Day	Date	Flow (L/M/H)	Pain (0 to 10)	Pain location	Other symptoms	Medicines or remedies	Helped?
1							
2							
3							
4							
5							
6							
7							
8							

Daily log: Month 2

Day	Date	Flow (L/M/H)	Pain (0 to 10)	Pain location	Other symptoms	Medicines or remedies	Helped?
1							
2							
3							
4							
5							
6							
7							
8							

Daily log: Month 3

Day	Date	Flow (L/M/H)	Pain (0 to 10)	Pain location	Other symptoms	Medicines or remedies	Helped?
1							
2							
3							
4							
5							
6							
7							
8							

If your period lasts longer than 8 days, add extra rows in your notebook.

Unusual bleeding or spotting log

Use this whenever you notice bleeding outside your period, after sex, or any unusual discharge or pain.

Date	What happened (spotting, bleeding, discharge, pain)	How long	Other symptoms	Possible pregnancy? (Yes / No / Not sure)

Heavy bleeding check

Tick any that apply this month.

- ☐ I soaked a pad in an hour or two.
- ☐ I used two pads at once.
- ☐ I changed my pad at night.
- ☐ I passed clots larger than a small coin.
- ☐ My period lasted more than 7 days.
- ☐ I felt dizzy, weak, very tired, or short of breath.

If you ticked several, or you soaked pads every hour for two hours or more with dizziness or weakness, go to Chapter 8 and Chapter 14.

Notes and questions for a healthcare professional

Write down anything you want to ask or tell a doctor, nurse, or pharmacist.

What to look for when you review your tracker

After three months, look at your tracker and ask:

- Is my **cycle length** roughly the same each month, or does it vary a lot?
- Is my **bleeding** getting heavier or longer?
- Is my **pain** getting worse, or lasting longer?
- Which days are **hardest,** and can I plan ahead for them?
- Which **remedies helped,** and which did not?
- Have I noticed **bleeding between periods**?
- Are there **patterns** linked to stress, travel, illness, or changes in food or exercise?

If any of these worry you, take your tracker to a health professional.

> **Key takeaway:** The tracker does not diagnose anything. It simply gives you and your clinician better information.

CHAPTER 13

Your Seven-Day Period Wellness Plan

A gentle week of self-care: water, food, movement, rest, and checking in.

This is a gentle plan to help you practise self-care during your period. It is a guide, not a test. If you cannot do everything, do what you can. Rest is not laziness.

Please remember: This plan can support your comfort and wellbeing, but it **cannot promise** to remove pain or correct irregular periods. If your symptoms are severe, getting worse, or worrying you, speak to a health professional.

Before you start

- Keep your tracker nearby.
- Prepare supplies: pads or other products, extra underwear, a clean towel, a water bottle.
- Have your comfort items ready: a hot-water bottle or warm cloth, a light blanket.
- If you use pain relief, check that you have it, and read the label.

Day 1: Prepare and comfort

- **Hydration:** Start the day with a glass of water, and keep a bottle nearby.
- **Meals:** Eat a simple, filling breakfast such as pap with moi moi, or oats with banana. Have regular meals through the day.
- **Movement:** A short, slow walk, or a few gentle stretches such as child's pose.
- **Rest and sleep:** Go to bed a little earlier if you can.
- **Heat:** Use a warm, covered water bottle on your lower belly for 15 to 20 minutes, never directly on skin and never while asleep.
- **Tracking:** Note Day 1 in your tracker.
- **Warning signs to watch for:** Very heavy bleeding, fainting, or severe pain. See Chapter 14.

Day 2: Be gentle with yourself

- **Hydration:** Sip water often. If you like, have a cup of ginger tea (food-strength, see Chapter 6).
- **Meals:** Include a protein and a vegetable at lunch and dinner, such as beans with ugu, or fish with vegetable soup.
- **Movement:** Light activity only. Stop if you feel dizzy.
- **Rest and sleep:** Try ten minutes of slow breathing, or a rest in a quiet room.
- **Heat:** A warm shower or a covered warm compress.
- **Tracking:** Fill in your pain score, flow, and what helped.

Day 3: Nourish

- **Hydration:** Water, and a fruit such as watermelon or orange.
- **Meals:** Add an iron-containing food, such as beans, eggs, fish, chicken, or dark green leafy vegetables, with a vitamin C food like orange or tomato.
- **Movement:** A gentle walk in the open air, if you feel able.
- **Rest and sleep:** Keep a regular bedtime.
- **Heat:** Use again if it helps.
- **Tracking:** Note anything unusual, such as large clots or very heavy flow.

Day 4: Move a little, rest a little

- **Hydration:** Keep your bottle with you.
- **Meals:** Do not skip meals. Have a snack such as groundnuts or a banana if you get hungry.
- **Movement:** A little stretching, or gentle housework at your own pace.
- **Rest and sleep:** If you can, take a short rest in the afternoon.
- **Heat:** As needed.
- **Tracking:** Write down what has helped most so far.

Day 5: Check in with your body

- **Hydration:** Water through the day.
- **Meals:** Enjoy something you like that is balanced, such as rice with vegetables and fish.
- **Movement:** A walk, or light dancing to music you enjoy.
- **Rest and sleep:** Reduce screen time before bed.
- **Tracking:** Review your tracker so far. How is your pain compared with Day 1? Is bleeding easing?
- **Warning signs:** If bleeding is still very heavy, or pain is getting worse, do not wait. See a health professional.

Day 6: Restore

- **Hydration:** Keep up your water.
- **Meals:** Include vegetables, protein, and a staple such as yam, sweet potato, or rice.
- **Movement:** Normal gentle activity, as you feel able.
- **Rest and sleep:** Try to get a full night's sleep.
- **Tracking:** Note the last days of bleeding and anything that surprised you.

Day 7: Reflect and prepare for next time

- **Hydration:** Continue with water.
- **Meals:** Have a balanced meal, and consider preparing a few easy foods for next month, such as boiled eggs or cooked beans.
- **Movement:** Whatever feels good.
- **Rest and sleep:** Aim for your usual sleep schedule.
- **Preparing supplies:** Restock pads, comfort items, and any pain relief you use. Fill in your period-care plan card from Chapter 3.
- **Tracking:** Fill in your cycle summary. Write down questions for a clinician if you have them.
- **Recognising when help is needed:** Look back at your week. If pain stopped you from normal life, bleeding was very heavy, or anything worried you, make an appointment.

A kind reminder

You are not failing if your pain does not disappear. Some women need medical treatment, and that is not a sign you did anything wrong.

Key takeaway: Small, kind habits add up. This plan supports you, and your health professional completes the picture.

CHAPTER 14

When to Seek Medical Help

A clear guide to urgent care and to booking an appointment.

Home care has its place. But knowing when to seek help is just as important. This chapter gives you a clear guide. Please read it twice and keep it somewhere you can find it easily.

These lists are not complete. If something feels severe, sudden, or frightening, do not wait to match it to a list. Trust your instincts and get help.

Seek emergency or urgent medical care for:

- **Severe or sudden pain** in the belly or pelvis, especially if it comes on quickly or is on one side.
- **Fainting, or severe dizziness,** or feeling that you might faint.
- **Heavy bleeding with weakness, breathlessness, chest pain, a racing heartbeat, or feeling faint.**
- **Soaking through a pad or tampon every hour for two or more hours in a row.**
- **Possible pregnancy with significant pain or bleeding.**
- **Heavy bleeding or severe pain after a recent pregnancy, miscarriage, or delivery.**
- **Fever or chills with pelvic pain or bleeding, or foul-smelling discharge.**
- **Any symptom that feels severe, quickly getting worse, or alarming.**

What to do: Go to the nearest hospital or emergency unit, or ask someone to take you. If you feel faint, lie down and do not travel alone if you can avoid it.

Arrange a medical appointment for:

- **Period pain that repeatedly affects school, work, sleep, or daily activities.**
- **Pain that is getting worse or is different from your usual pattern.**
- **Heavy or prolonged bleeding,** or tiredness that may be linked to heavy periods.
- **Repeatedly irregular periods.**
- **Periods that stop for several months** when pregnancy is not the explanation.
- **Pain during sex, bowel movements, or urination,** especially if it keeps coming back around your period.
- **Bleeding between periods or after sex.**
- **Needing pain relief every month just to cope,** or pain relief that no longer works.
- **Symptoms that do not improve with reasonable self-care.**
- **Any time you are worried,** even if your symptoms are not on this list.

> **What to do:** Visit a clinic, a hospital outpatient department, or a trusted doctor. Take your tracker and the checklist in Chapter 15. If you are not sure where to start, a pharmacist can advise you and tell you whether you should see a doctor.

“I don’t want to make a fuss”

Many women delay care because they feel embarrassed, worry about the cost, were told their pain is normal, or do not want to seem dramatic. These feelings are common and understandable, and they are not a reason to suffer.

- **You are not wasting anyone’s time.** Menstrual health is health.
- **Early care is often easier** than waiting until a problem has grown.
- **Cost is a real concern for many families.** If you are worried, ask about options. Some government and community health centres offer lower-cost care. A pharmacist can often advise you first.
- **If one professional dismisses your concerns,** it is reasonable to seek another opinion.

> **Key takeaway:** Home care and medical care work together. Do not let uncertainty, shame, or cost keep you from asking.

CHAPTER 15

How to Prepare for a Clinic Visit

What to bring, what to say, what to ask, and a checklist to take with you.

A clinic visit can feel stressful, especially if you are not used to talking about your periods. A little preparation helps you feel more confident and helps the clinician help you.

What information to write down

Before you go, collect the following. Your tracker from Chapter 12 holds most of it.

- **Your periods:** the dates of your last few periods, how long they last, and how long your cycles are.
- **Your bleeding:** how many pads you use in a day, how quickly they fill, clots, bleeding between periods, bleeding after sex.
- **Your pain:** when it starts, how long it lasts, where you feel it, and how bad it is on a scale of 0 to 10.
- **How it affects your life:** missed school or work, sleep problems, avoiding activities.
- **Other symptoms:** tiredness, dizziness, breathlessness, pain during sex, bowel or bladder symptoms, nausea, headaches.
- **Possibility of pregnancy:** the date of your last period and whether you could be pregnant.
- **What you have tried:** heat, rest, food, drinks, pain relief, and whether they helped.

- **Your health history:** other health conditions, past surgeries, and any family history of heavy periods, fibroids, endometriosis, or bleeding problems, if you know it.

How to describe pain and bleeding

Clear words help. You might say:

- “My pain starts about a day before my period and lasts for three days. At its worst it is 8 out of 10.”
- “It is in my lower belly and goes to my back.”
- “I have to change my pad every hour on the second day, and I pass clots about the size of a coin.”
- “I have missed school on two days of every period for the last four months.”
- “The pain is worse than it was last year.”

Do not be embarrassed. Clinicians hear about periods every day. Use your own words if that is easier.

How to mention medicines, supplements, and herbs

This is very important, and you will not be judged.

- Tell the clinician about **every** medicine you take, including

pain relievers, contraceptives, and anything from a pharmacy or shop.

- Tell them about **herbs, teas, tonics, or traditional mixtures** you have used, including the name or what it was made from if you know.
- Tell them about **vitamins and supplements**, including iron.
- If you can, **bring the bottles or packaging.**

Some herbs and supplements can affect blood tests, bleeding, or how medicines work. Honest information helps the clinician keep you safe.

Questions to ask the clinician

Choose the ones that matter to you.

1. What might be causing my symptoms?
2. Do I need any tests, such as blood tests or a scan? What will they show?
3. Could I be low on iron, and how can this be treated?
4. What treatment options are there, and what are the benefits and side effects?
5. Is it safe to use pain relief for my periods, and how should I take it?

6. Are there any remedies, foods, or herbs I should avoid?
7. Is there anything that would make you worry about my symptoms?
8. When should I come back, and what signs mean I should come sooner?
9. Could my symptoms affect my ability to get pregnant in the future?
10. What should I do if my pain or bleeding gets worse before my next visit?

Why honest conversations matter

You may feel shy talking about periods, sex, or private parts of the body. Please try to be honest anyway. The clinician can only help with what they know. Information about sex, possible pregnancy, and herbal products will not be used to judge you. It is used to make sure your care is safe and correct.

If you feel uncomfortable, you can ask to speak to a female clinician if one is available, or bring a trusted friend or relative for support.

Your clinic visit checklist

Before the visit

- ☐ I have my period tracker or notes.
- ☐ I know the date my last period started.
- ☐ I have written down my main symptoms and how they affect my life.
- ☐ I have listed all medicines, supplements, and herbs I use.
- ☐ I have written my questions.
- ☐ I have thought about whether I could be pregnant.
- ☐ I have money, a phone, and any records or earlier test results.
- ☐ I have arranged a trusted person to go with me, if I want.

During the visit

- ☐ I told the clinician about my pain and bleeding honestly.
- ☐ I mentioned any herbs or traditional remedies.
- ☐ I asked my questions.
- ☐ I understood the plan, or I asked the clinician to

explain again.

- ☐ I asked what warning signs mean I should return sooner.

After the visit

- ☐ I wrote down what the clinician said.
- ☐ I know how to take any medicine I was given.
- ☐ I know when my next appointment or test is.
- ☐ I will keep tracking my periods.

> **Key takeaway:** The best clinic visit is one where you feel heard. Preparation helps, but you do not need to be perfect. Just show up and speak honestly.

Conclusion: Your Body Deserves Care

Dear reader,

You have come a long way in this book. You have learned how your period works, why it can hurt, what you can do at home, how food and drinks fit in, what herbs and remedies we know and do not know, and when it is time to seek help.

If you take only a few things from these pages, we hope they are these:

- **Your pain is real,** and you deserve to be taken seriously.
- **Home care can bring comfort,** and small habits make a difference.
- **No food, drink, or herb is a cure-all,** and "natural" does not always mean "safe."
- **Heavy, irregular, or missed periods sometimes need a professional.**
- **Asking for help is not a sign of weakness.** It is a sign that you value your health.
- **Home care and medical care can work together.**

We hope you will keep tracking your cycle, speak up when something feels wrong, and share what you have learned with your sisters, friends, and daughters. When women talk openly about their health, fewer women suffer in silence.

Be patient and kind to yourself. Look for reliable information, and trust yourself when something does not feel right.

You deserve comfort, care, and good health.

With love and respect,
Women's Health Matters

References

These are the sources opened and checked while preparing this book (accessed 10 October 2026). References 5 to 8 are summaries compiled by reference databases and a university herbal-safety programme, not primary research studies.

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Further reading

Many general statements in this book (for example, typical cycle lengths, signs of heavy bleeding, and home pregnancy testing) reflect widely accepted medical guidance. For further reliable information, readers can visit the patient-information pages of the NHS, the American College of Obstetricians and Gynecologists (ACOG), NICE, the World Health Organization (WHO), and MedlinePlus, or speak to a qualified health professional.